



Discussions Rubric

Applies to all discussion prompts across Modules 1, 2, and 3

Total: 100 points

CLOs: 1, 4 (Module 1) · 2, 3, 5 (Module 2) · 4, 5, 6 (Module 3)

Type: Analytic · Weighted criteria

CRITERIA	EXCELLENT 100–90%	PROFICIENT 89–75%	DEVELOPING 74–60%	BEGINNING BELOW 60%
Content Knowledge & Engagement with Course Material 40% of total	Response demonstrates clear understanding of the module's core concepts. References specific content from readings, simulations, or activities to support observations and claims. Shows original thinking beyond surface-level description.	Response shows adequate understanding of module content. Makes some connection to course material but may rely on general statements rather than specific evidence from the module.	Response shows partial understanding. Connections to course content are vague or underdeveloped. May misidentify key concepts or describe them inaccurately.	Response shows minimal engagement with course content. Little to no connection between the discussion response and the module's learning material.
Critical Thinking & Higher-Order Analysis 30% of total	Response moves beyond observation to analyze why something happened, what it means, or how it connects to larger course themes. Poses or responds to genuinely complex questions. Shows synthesis across multiple ideas.	Response includes some analysis but tends toward description over interpretation. Makes straightforward connections without developing them further.	Response is mostly descriptive. Little analytical thinking evident beyond naming what was observed. Stays at the surface level of the prompt.	Response is superficial or restates the prompt without engaging with its substance. Does not demonstrate higher-order thinking.
Peer Engagement & Community Building 20% of total	Reply to peers is substantive and specific. Builds on what the peer said, asks a meaningful follow-up question, respectfully challenges a claim, or adds a genuinely new dimension to the conversation.	Reply to peers is relevant and respectful but stays at the surface. Mostly agrees or offers minimal extension without developing a new idea.	Reply to peers is brief or generic. Does not engage meaningfully with the peer's specific argument or observation.	No peer reply submitted, or reply is off-topic and does not engage with the peer's post in any meaningful way.
Clarity & Communication 10% of total	Writing is clear, organized, and easy to follow. No significant grammar or spelling errors. Technical terms from the module are used correctly when relevant.	Writing is mostly clear with minor errors that do not interfere with comprehension. Adequate organization throughout.	Writing has noticeable errors or unclear passages that occasionally interfere with comprehension. Organization is inconsistent.	Writing is difficult to follow due to frequent errors or disorganized structure that significantly impedes understanding.

SCORE KEY ● Excellent: 90–100 pts ● Proficient: 75–89 pts ● Developing: 60–74 pts ● Beginning: Below 60 pts

EQUITY & ACCESSIBILITY NOTE

This rubric evaluates quality of thinking and engagement, not prior knowledge of space science. A learner with no science background who reasons carefully from simulation observations will score as well as a learner with a science degree. Correct scientific vocabulary is rewarded but is not required for top marks. Plain language responses that demonstrate genuine reasoning receive full credit.